



Waterwheel

An AI agent that tests websites automatically

A test is described in plain English. Waterwheel then opens a real browser, runs it like a person would, and reports back — with no coding and no scripts to maintain.

Plain-English tests

Pennies per test

Runs anywhere

Data stays private

Testing a website today is slow and expensive

Before any new feature reaches customers, someone must confirm the site still works. The old ways cost hours and real money — every single release.

⌚ Time per full test round — ~7 hours by hand



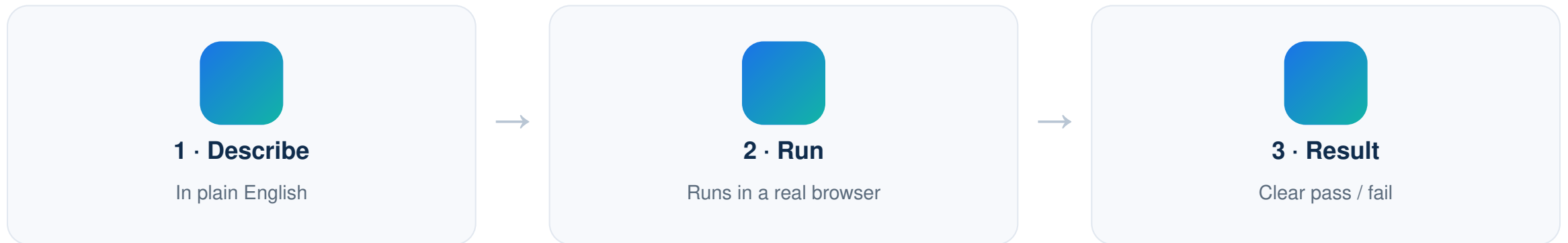
💰 Cost per full test round — ~\$390 by hand



Developer time Manual testing Writing test scripts Re-checking everything

It tests a website the way a person would

Three simple steps. No coding, no scripts to maintain.



Pennies

per test

Private

runs on the customer's own systems

Anywhere

any computer or system

Built for the messy, multi-step tests that break other tools

Real flows like **sign up** → **activate by email** → **start a paid subscription**, where each step depends on the one before it.

Capability	Script tools Selenium · Cypress	AI cloud tools testRigor · mabl	Waterwheel
Tests written in plain English	✗	✓	✓
Keeps working after a site redesign	✗	✓	✓
Handles long, multi-step journeys	~	✓	✓
Passes information from one step to the next (e.g. new logins, email links)	✗	~	✓
Runs on the customer's own systems — data never leaves	✓	✗	✓
Customer keeps full ownership — no vendor lock-in	✓	✗	✓
Works with the customer's choice of AI	—	✗	✓

Who uses it — and what they gain

For any team that builds or runs a website — software teams, startups, agencies, online businesses.



~8 min

unattended — vs ~7 hrs of human effort by hand



~1%

of manual testing cost



0

lines of code to write



100%

private — runs on the customer's systems

How we calculated the manual baseline

Bottom-up estimate for one full regression round of a web feature on a mid-size team. Deliberately conservative — real teams often spend more.

ROLE / ACTIVITY	TIME	LOADED RATE	COST
■ Developer time (setup & fixes)	1.0 h	\$90 / h	\$90
■ Manual testing	2.0 h	\$45 / h	\$90
■ Writing & maintaining test scripts	2.0 h	\$60 / h	\$120
■ Re-checking everything still works	2.0 h	\$45 / h	\$90
Total, one test round	7.0 h	—	\$390

Methodology & sources

Loaded rate = base salary × ~1.35 (benefits + overhead) ÷ ~2,080 work hours/year. Base salaries from US market data (Glassdoor, levels.fyi, BLS).

Waterwheel side is measured, not estimated: a real 3-test benchmark suite ran in 483 s (~8 min) at ~\$1.66 in API cost.

Robust to challenge: even if you halve every estimate above, Waterwheel is still ~25× faster and ~100× cheaper. The case rests on orders of magnitude, not any single figure.

Sources behind the comparison

Industry references used for the "Why It Wins" competitive claims (accessed July 2026).

Script tools break on brittle selectors; teams spend ~40–50% of test effort on maintenance

getautonoma.com/blog/selenium-playwright-cypress-comparison
stackoverflow.blog — Selenium vs Cypress vs Playwright (Jun 2026)

AI cloud tools removed selectors and made tests plain-English & self-healing (testRigor, mabl)

testrigor.com/alternative/mabl
getautonoma.com/blog/ai-testing-platform-comparison

2026 landscape of AI testing platforms and agentic (natural-language) test authoring

qa.tech/blog/the-13-best-ai-testing-tools-in-2026

Cloud-tool pricing — testRigor Pro ≈ \$900–1k/mo; mabl ≈ \$450–3k/mo, Enterprise \$40k+/yr

getautonoma.com/blog/testrigor-pricing
getautonoma.com/blog/mabl-pricing

Note: categories are representative of each approach, not exhaustive of every vendor. Cloud-tool pricing is third-party estimate — testRigor and mabl gate exact figures behind sales. Waterwheel has no license or subscription fee; you pay only your own AI provider's token usage (~\$1.66 measured for a 3-test benchmark run, i.e. pennies per test). Waterwheel capabilities are drawn from its own product documentation.